



session, one would have expected the Indian batters to exhibit the sort of restraint Muthusamy and Verreynne showed.

Instead, they went the other way, sabotaging their chances of levelling the series with miscalculated shot-making early on Day 3, as India collapsed from 95 for one to 122 for seven in the space of 68 deliveries.

The blinding inability to adapt was also evident at the individual level. Take the case of Jaiswal.

Despite knowing that his tendency to cut at rising deliveries angling away from him has become a well-identified weakness, the left-handed opener failed to deny himself the temptation. Three of his four dismissals in the series came against Jansen, all from ill-advised cut shots.

For all one could harp on India's shortcomings, it was also a case of being bettered by a South African side that appears close to its zenith under coach Shukri Conrad.

This series win, its first in India in 25 years, is the strongest stamp of validation South Africa has received

since its coronation as World Test Champion earlier this year.

One could argue that the team benefited from several crucial moments going its way, such as Gill's injury and winning both tosses.

But to reduce this win to those instances would be to discredit South Africa's precision in planning, clarity in approach and ruthlessness in execution.

Over the last decade, South Africa's tours of India were characterised by the domination of Indian spinners.

But this time, there was a reversal of roles. Proteas spinners, led by the uncontrollable Harmer, outbowled their Indian counterparts.

South Africa also made a few surprising selection choices that delivered immediate dividends — for instance, opting for Corbin Bosch in Kolkata and bringing back Muthusamy in Guwahati. Both delivered the goods with the bat while also chipping in with wickets.

To top it off, South Africa won the contest despite a significant handicap — its biggest star, pacer Kagiso Rabada, missed the series due to a rib

Talent aplenty: The transition excuse is a disservice to the quality of players at Gautam Gambhir's disposal.

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injury. It is another matter that the visiting team sealed its landmark triumph in front of near-empty stands, a continuation of Guwahati's lukewarm response to its first-ever Test match.

Even at its best, on Day 2, a Sunday, the Barsapara Stadium was far from full. As India's fortunes dwindled in the Test, so did the enthusiasm in the stands.

More importantly, India struggled to adapt to Guwahati's conditions, having almost no red-ball experience at this venue. Taking Test cricket to newer venues like Guwahati definitely expands the horizon of red-ball cricket in the country. However, if it comes at the cost of India squandering its home advantage, is it worth it?

But, again, is this Indian team capable of capitalising on any such benefit?